Early Morning from Times of War

By Eric Lane

Characters

DORIS HANSON, *sixties to early seventies. Her grandson, Kenny, has just died. Her world has been turned upside down. She is experiencing a strong range of emotions-from grief to rage to relief. She is forced to protect herself and Kenny's memory.*

DIAMANTINI, *a detective. Working class, with a slight belly. Married, and the father of three girls. Has been on the force since his twenties. Having solved many disturbing cases, he still cares in spite of himself. A strong sense of right and wrong. While sometimes appearing casual, he drives the investigation and knows exactly what he is doing.*

DORIS: In times of peace, children bury their parents. In times of war, we bury our sons.

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR: *The year: 1994. Doris is accused of a shocking crime.*
ACTRESS: *Dori's grandson Kenny has died in a hospital under mysterious circumstances.*
ACTOR: *Doris was the last person seen alone with her grandson, Kenny, who was dying of AIDS and who she loved dearly. She is accused of killing her grandson by suffocating him with a pillow.*
ACTRESS: *Doris claims she is innocent and finds herself at the center of a media frenzy. Detective Diamantini is assigned to investigate the case.*
TOGETHER: *Early Morning from Times of Way by Eric Lane.*

DORIS: *[Straightforward.]* I did not kill my grandson.

DIAMANTINI: No?

DORIS: No. I had gotten there this morning at six-fifteen.

DIAMANTINI: *[Sits.]* How come so early?

DORIS: Kenny would wake up. Maybe the noise. Or just being there, in the

hospital. Two and a half months this time. This time, two and a half months. If I was there, he wouldn't- He would be, well, calmer. Maybe talk. Just a few-words.

DIAMANTINI: Doris? He'd be calmer if you came. . . . You were saying-

DORIS: Kenny. Do you have any children?

DIAMANTINI: Three girls. Play the violin. I hate that instrument. All strings.

DORIS: Kenny played the piano.

DIAMANTINI: Was he good?

DORIS: *[Nods.]* I used to listen. I liked listening, when he played. I taught him.

DIAMANTINI: You still play? [DORIS: *nods.]* Me, I got no musical ability.

DORIS: Everyone has some musical ability.

DIAMANTINI: I play you sixteen bars on trumpet, you'll think different. So it's just you this morning. Alone with Kenny. You'd talk.

DORIS: *[Nods.]* Like every morning.

DIAMANTINI: Me, six-fifteen, I'm not saying much. That's just me. What'd you talk about?

DORIS: It was his birthday. Twenty-nine years old. I brought him a cupcake with an electric candle in it. Turned it on and sang "Happy Birthday."

DIAMANTINI: I bet he liked that.

DORIS: Blew out the candle. I helped him. Took off his oxygen mask and blew it out. He saw it was electric, but still ...

DIAMANTINI: What'd he wish for?

DORIS: I don't know. Even if I did, can't tell or it won't come true. . . . Saturn Return. You asked what we talked about.

DIAMANTINI: What's that?

DORIS: This time of big change. Once every twenty-nine years. Kenny read all about it.

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DIAMANTINI: So you're in the hospital with Kenny. Two and a half months now.

DORIS: This time.

DIAMANTINI: This time, two and a half months.

DORIS: Yes.

DIAMANTINI: This morning, in his room, singing "Happy Birthday." By yourself the whole time.

DORIS: Nurses would come and go, but yes, I was there. Until I left the room at eight-thirty.

DIAMANTINI: You knew what time it was?

DORIS: I looked at my watch. It was eight-thirty. I went to the pay phone to call my daughter. Margie was at work by then.

DIAMANTINI: Kenny's mom. [DORIS *nods.]* And nothing seemed unusual.

DORIS: No.

DIAMANTINI: Was Kenny upset?

DORIS: He seemed calm, relaxed. He said he had a good night's sleep.

DIAMANTINI: It seems we got a couple of questions.

DORIS: What kind of questions?

DIAMANTINI: When his nurse-

DORIS: Carole.

DIAMANTINI: When Carole came in the room there was a pillow across Kenny's face. This is when you're making your call. His hands are at his side. His oxygen mask off and on the night table just out of his reach. Not impossible to reach, just slightly beyond. Do you understand what I'm asking? [DORIS: *says nothing.]* Nobody else was in the room. The curtain was drawn around the bed.

DORIS: People look in. You want your privacy. . . . They didn't want to let me back in the room. His doctors. I made them. Kenny lying there. It's

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his birthday. Saturn Return. This time when Saturn returns to the exact position when you were born.. He's gone, I think. "Who he really is is gone. And anything that follows doesn't scare me-what they say or think, doesn't matter, 'cause I know he's safe. Ask your questions, Detective. Ask away.

(SCENE BREAK)

[DORIS and DIAMANTINI address the audience. They hear what each other says.)

DORIS: There is no word. I'm suspected of a crime without a word. A son kills his mother-

DIAMANTINI: Matricide.

DORIS: A mother kills her baby

DIAMANTINI: Infanticide.

DORIS: But the thought of a woman killing her child's child. It's not even part of the language. Because no one would believe it. No one.

(SCENE BREAK)

DIAMANTINI: You're in the room. Eight-thirty. And you're heading to ...

DORIS: The pay phone.

DIAMANTINI: OK. You reach the pay phone.

DORIS: The lounge is empty-TV on but empty, and I call Margie. Nothing important, just to say hello. She sends him her love. "Tell Kenny happy birthday and I'll see him later tonight."

DIAMANTINI: So you get off the phone and head back to the room.

DORIS: Head back, only everything feels different.

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DIAMANTINI: Different how?

DORIS: Outside. The hall feels like-I don't know. Movie time. Slower. Just not me, but away, and this part of me- Just this part has this feeling like- *[Searches for the words, can't find them.)*

DIAMANTINI: And when you get back to the room. [DORIS: *looks away.)* "When you get back-

DORIS: "When I get back to the room there are people. Nurses, doctors. The door's closed and I know . . . I know. In the time it took for me to call Margie and tell her everything is fine, Kenny died. And you think I did it.

DIAMANTINI: I didn't say that.

DORIS: No?

DIAMANTINI: No. I'm just trying to figure out what happened. Help me out here. I got one question. Why'd you leave the room?

DORIS: To use the phone.

DIAMANTINI: Phone in the room.

DORIS: I wasn't going to talk in front of Kenny.

DIAMANTINI: Why not? He's your grandson.

DORIS: And he's dying. Do you think I want to talk about that in front of him?

DIAMANTINI: So you're gonna walk down two long hallways. Pay twenty-five cents, when a phone's right there in the room.

DORIS: Yes.

DIAMANTINI: Doesn't add up.

DORIS: You have daughters.

DIAMANTINI: We're talking about your grandson.

DORIS: Your daughter's lying in bed, and you're watching her. Pretending

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nothing's wrong. Like nothing's been wrong the past three years. Watching her weight go down to ninety. Barely able to lift her head. Every morning at six-fifteen. You sit in that hospital room. You sit in that chair and watch and wait and pray and you tell me. You tell me if you'd step out of the room for five minutes.

DIAMANTINI: Maybe I would. Maybe I'd want it to end. Her suffering like that. Did you?

DORIS: Did I what?

DIAMANTINI: Want it to end?

DORIS: No.

DIAMANTINI: Sitting in that chair. Watching and waiting. Praying. You must've thought about it.

DORIS: No.

DIAMANTINI: Blowing out that candle, there must've been something you wished for. [DORIS: *looks away.]* Maybe he wanted it, too. Even asked you to help him.

DORIS: No.

DIAMANTINI: Three years and not once ...

DORIS: You don't think. You just do what you have to do.

DIAMANTINI: Whatever he needs.

DORIS: Yes.

DIAMANTINI: To stop the pain.

DORIS: If I could. Yes. If I could make him more comfortable. [*A beat.]* A miracle. *[He looks at her.]* You asked what I wished for. When I blew out the candle. I wanted a miracle. [*A moment.]*

DIAMANTINI: So that morning, Kenny makes his wish. Takes off his oxygen mask. Blows out the candle. Then puts it back on.

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DORIS: Yes.

DIAMANTINI: Why not wait?

DORIS: For what?

DIAMANTINI: Me, I'd wait. 'Til later. Other people around. Presents.

DORIS: It was his birthday. I thought it might cheer him up.

DIAMANTINI: Was he depressed?

DORIS: He was in the hospital. What do you think?

DIAMANTINI: But you said he wasn't. He had a good night's sleep. Isn't that what you said?

DORIS: Yes.

DIAMANTINI: Then he wasn't depressed.

DORIS: No.

DIAMANTINI: You just said he was.

DORIS: I said-

DIAMANTINI: He was. He wasn't.

DORIS: *[Mispronounces his name.]* Detective Damanitini . . . He was about five-eleven, black wavy hair. I saw him just as I was leaving the nurse's station.

DIAMANTINI: Who?

DORIS: This man. I'm leaving the nurse's station and turning to head down the hall. And I see him go into Kenny's room.

DIAMANTINI: And you don't think to say anything about it 'til now.

DORIS: He was dressed like staff. I thought nothing of it at the time. People were always coming in and out of the room. No more than a glimpse. A moment of seeing him from behind. I had no reason to think anything was wrong. Would you? [DIAMANTINI: *looks at her.* DORIS: *holds the look].*

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DIAMANTINI: Was he wearing sneakers or shoes

DORIS: They were white. What difference does it make? I don't remember.

DORIS: Put yourself in my position

DIAMANTINI: Doris . . .

DORIS: If it were your daughter . . . If she had been sick

DIAMANTINI: It's a simple question

DORIS: If she had been dying . . . Lying there - If it had been you?

DIAMANTINI: But it's not! *[Quietly.]* It's not me. *[A moment.]* My brother. He's got it. Nobody knows. My wife, she doesn't want him near our girls. Like they can get it just by being near him. Like it's his fault if he gets sick.

DORIS: I'm sorry.

DIAMANTINI: Yeah ... Yeah ... Anyway-

(SCENE BREAK)

[DORIS and DIAMANTINI: address the audience.]

DORIS: People talk. Friends call. Appear. Disappear. Girls in gym uniforms wave as I drive by, then scream to their friends in disbelief. "It was her."

DIAMANTINI: "Really."

DORIS: "Gross."

DIAMANTINI: "It was."

DORIS: "No way."

DIAMANTINI: "As if."

DORIS: "Her." A group of high school boys pulls up to the house and waits. They throw a pillow on the lawn, gun the engine and laugh hysterically as they drive off into the night. The nights are lonely. The morning. Afternoon.

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Margie, she keeps busy with work, but me ... I go for a walk. Come home. Sit. Wait for something to do. To take care of.

DIAMANTINI: When a murder case goes to trial, a jury's got two choices: guilty and not guilty. Not guilty doesn't mean you didn't do it.

DORIS: Innocent would mean you didn't do it. In our court system, innocence isn't an option. Even after I'm acquitted, the same questions remain.

DIAMANTINI: The oxygen mask ...

DORIS: It's possible Kenny took it off and tossed it aside.

DIAMANTINI He could've put the pillow over his own face. Yeah, Kenny's hands were at his side, but they could've fallen. After he suffocated.

DORIS: It's possible someone came in the room. It's possible, they say, it was me.

DIAMANTINI No fingerprints show up but Kenny's, hers, and the hospital staff. No smoking gun.

DORIS: No bloody glove.

DIAMANTINI:. An act of mercy. Desperation . Violence. A grandson's request.

DORIS: A grandmother's love.

(SCENE BREAK)

DIAMANTINI: There was no other man. In the room. We both know ...

DORIS: I know what I saw.

DIAMANTINI: Off the record. . . Between us.

DORIS: If it were you, if it were your brother, can you honestly tell me what you would do?

DIAMANTINI: I want to know. Was it you?

DORIS: Between us? "Yes, it was me." Like at the end of one of those Perry

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Mason shows. Always at the end somebody stands up in the courtroom, who you thought was a bit part-the gardener or maybe the family cook-finally stands up and says they're really the murder victim's ex-husband or daughter. "Yes. Yes. I did it!" they cry out. "And you want to know why ... I" *[A moment. Then ...]* How often has that happened on one of your cases?

DIAMANTINI: Why won't you tell me?

DORIS: What you want to hear.

DIAMANTINI: The truth.

DORIS: A single answer. I remember a time when questions had a single answer. There was right and wrong. Good and evil. All this talk, it still doesn't bring Kenny back.

DIAMANTINI: So that's your answer?

DORIS: There is no answer. I've watched the men in my family die. Cut down, one after the other. And this is what we've become. In my day, we knew the enemy. But now ... Good. Evil. Black. White. Now it's all shades of gray.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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